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Group 5 Project Idea

SubletMatch: SubletMatch is a campus-only platform matching students leaving for internships or breaks with students needing short-term housing, adding trust and verification beyond scattered group chats and platforms.

1. Target Customer – Is it defined and easy to reach?

Yes and yes. Our target customer is college and graduate students who are leaving for the summer and/or for internships. Since we are on a university campus and are students ourselves, we have a solid foundation to reach our target audience. Moreover, University of Southern California is a school that: 1) has a large number of students 2) has a large population of students who intern during the year, are spring admits, and study abroad 3) is in Los Angeles, where there are lots of other colleges and where lots of students come to intern in over the summer and need a temporary place to stay.

2. Problem – Is this a real problem you're solving? How do you know? Data

Yes, because housing is a challenge and biggest need for students attending school, interning, and working. Not many locations and companies offer short term rental housing or apartments. Finding subleasing options can be difficult, risky, and challenging through informal and unofficial platforms, people, groups, and organizations. Having a safe, secure, official, and vetted platform helps people find and match with short term housing and helps students leaving to sublet their place where everyone is vetted and verified before using the platform, providing confidence, assurance, and safety. Our solution will make it easier for students to find short term housing, saving time having to vet and sort through many different people and platforms.

Data:

- Total Student Population: 46,000
(<https://www.usc.edu/we-are-usc/the-university/facts-and-stats/>)
- Undergraduates: 21,000
- Graduate and Professional: 25,000
- Expected graduating students in a year: 18K

- Expected incoming students in a year: ~6k estimate

This would imply there is a large turnover rate which would increase the likelihood of students at USC who would be interested in these services.

3. Competition – How do people currently solve this problem? Are there other competitors?

Currently, people use Facebook groups, word of mouth, friends, peers, classmates, and their own housing management companies to solve this problem. There certainly is competition, but the market is fragmented, leaving open space for a strong, consolidated and trustworthy app by and for students could be very useful.

4. Do you need a large number of people to provide utility? (i.e. a marketplace)

Yes. This app definitely relies on users to make it useful as it is a marketplace. That will likely be a challenge for us to overcome. However, for our project, we can test it with a small sample to gauge data analysis, behaviors, and patterns.

We will initially constrain the marketplace to USC and seed the prototype with a small set of realistic listings. We can then test whether students can successfully discover relevant listings, perceive verification as valuable, and express willingness to list or contact another student. The semester MVP is intended to validate the matching and trust hypotheses rather than achieve campus-wide marketplace liquidity.

5. How well does your product solve the problem?

We are solving for the following major pain points:

1. Fragmented listings.
 - a. Currently all other solutions provide a messy set of options for students looking to make a sublet decision, we plan to consolidate our listings so that we can provide one USC-focused marketplace where students that are incoming or outgoing can find or post sublets to make the process easier.
2. Uncertainty about identity
 - a. We plan to verify all listings, allowing for less anxiety and uncertainty surrounding the sublet process. Subletters will be able to communicate with verified students who are subletting their

places and those with sublets can feel less concern about putting their addresses on a platform.

3. Difficult discovery

- a. The app will have pictures and any reviews for locations, and will consolidate all short term listings and allow filters for duration, price, amenities, location (e.g DPS zone/Fryft availability), and campus convenience.

6. What would your Press Release headline be?

SubletMatch Solves the Short Term Housing Challenge for USC Students

7. How difficult is it to create the product? What are Major Features? Can you launch by week 9!

Not very difficult if we keep the goal(s), features, and objective(s) simple, realistic, and straightforward.

Our semester MVP has the following major features:

1. USC/student verification simulation
2. Create a sublet listing
3. Browse/search listings
4. Filter by dates, price, location and basic preferences
5. Listing detail page
6. Express interest/contact lister

AI Use Disclosure: Our team used ChatGPT to critique the product concept, identify gaps in our initial analysis, and help refine the organization and wording of this submission. We independently reviewed the recommendations, verified factual information using the cited sources, and made the final decisions regarding the product concept, scope, and content.